

Brazil, the African influence remains strong, particularly in coastal communities. The Brazilian state of Bahia specializes in seafood dishes of African origin, such as *acarajé*. Brazil is blessed with a wide variety of culinary trends, and with a coastline of some 4,660 miles (7,500 km), it's no wonder fish and seafood feature heavily. The *moqueca capixaba*, a hearty fish stew flavored with annatto seeds, hot peppers, and cilantro looks as well as tastes fantastic, the annatto coloring the dish a bright orange.

South American Feasting

From the crashing waves of the vast Atlantic, it's a short hop to the evergreen, huge grassy plains of the Argentinian pampas, home of the gauchos, Argentina's own cowboys. These hardy souls, most often found on horseback, have the enviable responsibility of taking care of the country's most prized asset – its cattle.

Argentinian meat is legendary, and there is nothing quite like a *parrillada* – a meat feast where all the best cuts, masterfully grilled and lightly seasoned, are served until diners can eat no more, all washed down with a fine local red wine.

In neighboring Chile, on the island of Chiloé, slow food is taken to dizzying heights in *curanto*, another form of feast, but one that's traditionally left to steam-cook in a hole in the ground. This far south in the Andean region, food goes with the climate and tends to be not just heart-warming, but body-warming as well.

Ecuador's *locro de papa* takes full advantage of the local ingredient *par excellence* – the potato. With 3,000 varieties found in the Andean countries alone, there's no shortage of choice, and the humble potato has rarely tasted better than in this creamy soup, with nothing but a sliver of garlic, some chopped onion, and a slice of bright green avocado to top it off.

The Andes climb farther north into Colombia and Venezuela, where they have devised different ways of keeping warm and well-nourished, choosing the one meat that is otherwise somewhat underrepresented elsewhere in South America – the humble pig. In Colombia, the *bandeja paisa*, originally from the center of the country but now found everywhere, is a celebration of all things porky. Ground pork, sausages, cracklings, and pork cuts all jostle for space in this dish, colorfully accompanied by rice, beans, salad, avocado, and fried potatoes, and topped off with a fried egg. Not for the cholesterol-conscious. Venezuela's *chicharrones*, or pork cracklings, seem positively restrained by comparison. All across the continent there are vastly varied culinary adventures waiting to be enjoyed, with a mix of influences as unique as the continent itself.

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Left Fresh fish landed from small fishing boats in Dalcahue Port, Chiloé Island, Chile
Below Cooking ribs and meat on an open fire, Buenos Aires, Argentina

